

ENGLISH, POWER, ACCESS

Why English Dominated

POWER BUILT NETWORK EFFECTS

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No single cause explains dominance

POWER

Empire

Networks crossed
borders.

INSTITUTIONS

Rules

Systems rewarded
English.

CULTURE

Media

Content travelled
widely.

TECHNOLOGY

Scale

Existing
advantages
multiplied.

Advantages accumulated over time.

Britain built global networks



Empire spread infrastructure, not superiority.

America reinforced existing networks

ECONOMY

Trade rewarded English.

RESEARCH

Universities attracted scholars.

MEDIA

Films and music travelled.

TECHNOLOGY

Platforms reached globally.

Earlier networks gained new force.

Institutions rewarded shared language

AVIATION

English standards

Safety rules created demand.

DIPLOMACY

Working language

Translation preserved plurality.

RESEARCH

Shared publishing

Access rewards accumulated.

Shared rules rewarded prior knowledge.

Multilingual systems still survived.

Technology amplified earlier advantage

EARLY INTERNET

US research networks

ARPANET began during 1969.

DOMAIN NAMES

ASCII foundations

Unicode needed later encoding.

WEB CONTENT

49.5% English

Measured 24 September 2026.

Technology inherited existing power.

Rivals never disappeared

UNITED NATIONS

Six official languages

Arabic · Chinese · English
French · Russian · Spanish

EUROPEAN UNION

Twenty-four official languages

Law remains multilingual.

Dominance never meant monopoly.

Language power can change.

Sources and limits

Crystal, 2003

History and culture

Internet Society

Network history

ICAO and ICANN

Institutional standards

UN, EU, W3Techs

Current language evidence

EVIDENCE

INFERENCE

UNPROVEN

NEXT: Conspiracies about English